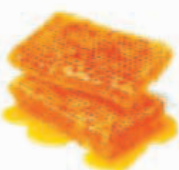


LALIBELA ETHIOPIA

Injera in Holy Lalibela

Dubbed “Africa’s Petra” for its astonishing rock-hewn churches, Lalibela has drawn Western visitors since the 16th century. It is hidden high in the Ethiopian highlands, and the journey is long and arduous for the thousands of pilgrims who travel there on foot. Many seek replenishment in its famous, pancake-like flatbread, *injera*, topped by a hot, steaming, and revitalizing stew.



Cradle of the Zagwe dynasty in the 12th and 13th centuries, Lalibela was once the country’s capital and the home of kings. According to local tradition, the town’s ruler and namesake, King Lalibela, was briefly forced into exile to Jerusalem by his evil, usurping brother. Amazed by the churches there, Lalibela vowed to build a holy city on African soil upon his return to his homeland.

Lalibela’s churches are exceptional for three main reasons: their artistic refinement, their sophisticated construction (many are not just carved into the rock, but freed entirely from it), and their number – so many are found within such a small area. For the visitor, Lalibela’s unique appeal also lies in its timeless continuity. Monks and deacons, traditionally robed, glide along the candlelit passageways and tunnels that connect the medieval churches, and the sound of chanting still rises from the hidden crypts and grottoes. The deep, cool recesses of the extraordinary church interiors are filled with the heady fragrance of incense and burning beeswax candles.

What to Drink in Lalibela

Once the drink of Ethiopian emperors and kings, *tej* – a kind of mead – is now the popular local tipple. Made from locally produced honey and an Ethiopian shrub called *gesho*, it is found today in the *tej beats* (a kind of Ethiopian equivalent of pubs) in most Ethiopian towns, as well as in higher-end restaurants. Served in delightful little flasks known as *birille*, *tej* comes in varying degrees of sweetness. Ask for *derek* if you want it dry and strong (the drier it is, the more alcoholic the content), *mahakalenya* for medium-sweet, and *laslasa* or *bers* for a sweeter and less alcoholic version. Local men congregate at *tej beats* to gossip, cogitate, and commiserate. As in Western pubs, most men tend to gather during a weekend afternoon, while women traditionally drink *tej* from glasses during market days as they work and exchange news.

The taverns and restaurants of Lalibela have also been serving the pilgrims for centuries. They offer up an often quite sophisticated and eclectic cuisine that includes piquant meat *wats* (stews) and mild, smooth curries of vegetables and beans. Underpinning all – literally – is the country’s staple, *injera*, a kind of large, round flatbread upon which the cooks heap one or more meat and vegetable dishes. Used as a base and also as a tool (small pieces are torn off with the right hand and used to pick at the dishes), *injera* famously serves as foodstuff, plate, and cutlery.

Injera is traditionally made from the flour of *teff*, a small-grained indigenous Ethiopian cereal that is found throughout the Ethiopian highlands. This distinguishes the higher-quality *injera*, which is lighter, smoother, thinner, and springier than non-*teff* varieties. After a day’s exploration of Lalibela’s wondrous churches, there’s no better way to end the day than by tucking in to *injera* and a large, communal plate of steaming, slightly spicy stew with some new-found friends. Ethiopians believe that sharing a meal in this way cements a friendship forever.



Above *Injera* dough is fermented overnight, then cooked like a pancake



The Best Places to Eat Injera

Blue Lal Hotel Restaurant

inexpensive

Although Lalibela and its extraordinary churches are becoming better known and visitor numbers are increasing, the range and quality of the town’s restaurants (and hotels) remain rather limited. One of the better options for sampling Ethiopian food is the Blue Lal Hotel Restaurant. Designed like a *tukul* (traditional Ethiopian hut), complete with freshly cut grass strewn on the floor and multicolored *mesobs* (traditional, mushroom-shaped dining tables woven like baskets) dotting the dining floor, the Blue Lal Restaurant serves fresh, authentic, and good-quality Ethiopian dishes, including a well-prepared *injera*, at excellent prices. Try the unctuous *doro wat*: chicken drumsticks or wings accompanied by hard-boiled egg served in a hot sauce of butter, onion, and cardamom and a good sprinkling of *berbere* (a spice mixture of up to 16 ingredients, including the fiery *beri-beri*). If you don’t fancy stew, try *kitfo*, minced beef or lamb traditionally served warm but not cooked – like a form of steak tartare – and flavored with the even hotter *mitmita* spice mixture.

Downtown Lalibela; +251 3 3336 0380

Also in Lalibela

The **Seven Olives Hotel** (+251 3 3336 0020; *inexpensive*) is furnished with Ethiopian arts and crafts and offers the classic range of *injera-plus-wats*, as well as *injera* and *ye som megeb* (vegetarian dishes traditionally served on Friday, the day of fasting). If you’re eager to taste multiple Ethiopian dishes, request the *beyanatu* – you’ll receive small portions of different meat and vegetable dishes.

Also in Ethiopia

Habesha Restaurant (+251 3 3351 8358; *moderate*) in Addis-Ababa is traditionally decorated and known for its good-quality, more eclectic menu, including *injera*-accompanied dishes such as *dulet* (minced tripe, liver, and beef fried in butter, onions, chili pepper, and cardamom) and *kwanta* (strips of beef rubbed in chili pepper, butter, salt, and *berbere*). In the evening, there’s live Ethiopian music or dancing.

Around the World

London has a sizable Ethiopian community and **Wabe Shebele Restaurant** (+44 20 7378 9009; *moderate*) serves authentic Ethiopian food in a traditionally decorated dining room. Regulars include *gored gored* (warmed cubes of raw beef served with spiced Ethiopian butter) and *goden tibs* (lamb ribs sautéed with *berbere* and rosemary). On weekends, there is traditional Ethiopian dancing.